Condition Overview

Health Screening Guidelines for Men Ages 18 to 39

Health screenings help keep you well at all ages. Even when you are not sick, seeing your care team regularly keeps your body working well and prevents sickness by guiding you to a healthy lifestyle. At these visits, your care team can provide preventive care services like updating vaccines. These visits mean that you and your care team know each other in case of an illness.

If you are between the ages of 18 and 39, this guide will help you learn about what to expect during healthcare screenings and when to talk to your care team.

Physical Exam

Once a year, your care team will do a full physical exam. This is a head-to-toe exam that can include checking your

- Heart and lungs
- Blood pressure
- Height and weight to measure your body mass index, called BMI

During this exam, your care team will ask about

- Mental health and wellness. This is an important way to check for any signs of anxiety or depression. Talk to them about any concerns you have.
- Healthy eating and exercise.
- Alcohol and tobacco use.
- Safety, along with any intimate partner violence.
- Any medicines and supplements you take.
- Any allergies you have.
- Your past health history and any family history of disease.
- Skin cancer prevention and sun safety.

- Any immunizations you have had.

Other important screenings are available for men between the ages of 18 and 39. Talk to your care team about these screenings.

Blood Pressure Screening

Who? Men aged 18 and older.

How often? One time per year for men who are not at risk for high blood pressure.

What should you expect? Your blood pressure is checked to see if it is in the normal range. It consists of a top number called systolic blood pressure and a bottom number called diastolic blood pressure. It is measured in mmHg, which stands for millimeters of mercury.

Blood pressure is in the normal range when the top number is lower than 120 mmHg and the bottom number is lower than 80 mmHg.

Your care team may want to check your blood pressure more often if your top number is between 120 and 129 mmHg or your bottom is 70 to 79 mmHg. They will check your blood pressure more often if you

- Have kidney or heart problems
- Are over a healthy weight
- Are living with diabetes
- Have a close family member with high blood pressure
- Use tobacco or vape
- Drink too much alcohol
- Do not exercise often
- Have too much salt or have low potassium
- Have high levels of stress

A nurse checking blood pressure during a health screening.

Race can also be a factor. High blood pressure is more common in Black people. If your top number is above 130 mmHg or your bottom number is above 80 mmHg when taken at different times, this is called high blood pressure or hypertension.

At first, high blood pressure might not have any symptoms, but it can cause your organs to stop working over time. It is important to watch your blood pressure and treat it if it is high. Talk to your care team about how often to get checked and what treatment is right for you to stay healthy.

Cholesterol Screening

Who? Men aged 18 or older.

How often? Every 5 years for normal cholesterol levels. You will be tested more often if you have risk factors for high cholesterol, are on medicine for cholesterol, or have had high cholesterol in the past.

What should you expect? A lipid panel test checks your cholesterol levels. You may need to plan for this blood test in the morning, before eating or drinking anything except water for 8 hours before the test. Your care team will tell you if you need to do this. These are the normal levels.

- **Total Cholesterol,** less than 200 mg/dL
- **LDL Cholesterol**, sometimes called bad cholesterol. Less than 100 mg/dL
- **HDL Cholesterol**, often called good cholesterol. At least 40 mg/dL or higher, 60 mg/dL or higher can help protect against heart disease and stroke
- **Triglycerides,** less than 150 mg/dL

High cholesterol can lead to the buildup of plaque in your blood vessels. This can lead to heart disease or stroke. If your cholesterol is high, your care team will suggest changes to your diet and activity level. Healthy eating and exercise can help improve your cholesterol levels. Your care team may suggest medicine to lower your level.

Diabetes Screening

Who? Men aged 35 and older. Talk to your doctor about screening if you are younger than 35 and have risk factors like obesity or a family history of diabetes.

How often? At least every 3 years.

What should you expect? A blood test will measure your blood sugar levels to check for diabetes.

Diabetes is a condition where your blood sugar levels are too high because your body does not make or use insulin well. Testing can help find diabetes early.

Fasting blood sugar before meals or after at least 8 hours of fasting

- Normal 70-99 mg/dL
- Prediabetes 100-125 mg/dL
- Diabetes 126 mg/dL or higher on two separate tests

Blood sugar after meals

- Normal less than 140 mg/dL

Hemoglobin A1C testing

- Normal below 5.7%
- Prediabetes 5.7% to 6.4%
- Diabetes 6.5% or higher

If blood sugar levels stay high, it can lead to serious health problems like heart disease, kidney damage, and vision loss. Testing will help manage the health problem and prevent other problems.

Immunizations

Who? Men 18 years and older.

How often? Based on the vaccine schedule.

What should you expect? Many vaccines are needed to stay healthy. The type of vaccine and the number of doses you need depends on your age and health. Common vaccines for men ages 18 to 39 include,

- **Flu shot.** Get a flu shot each year during flu season to stay healthy.
- **COVID-19 Vaccine.** Based on current guidelines, talk to your care team about what is best for you depending on your risk.

- **Pneumococcal Vaccines**. This is given around age 65 but may be given sooner if you are at high risk for lung infections.
- **Hepatitis A and B Vaccines.** Your care team might suggest these vaccines based on travel, your job, or health problems.
- **HPV vaccine.** If you have not received the full series of HPV vaccines in your early teenage years, talk to your care team about this vaccine. Your care team will help you decide what is best for you.
- **Measles, mumps, and rubella (MMR) vaccine.** Get 1 to 2 doses if you do not have MMR immunity. Talk to your care team to check if you are current on this vaccine.
- **Tetanus-diphtheria.** A booster shot is recommended every 10 years.
- **Varicella vaccine.** If you have not had chickenpox, 2 doses of the varicella vaccine are recommended.

Less common vaccines include,

- **Haemophilus influenzae Type B (HIB).** This is given to some adults who have a weak immune system or are at high risk.
- **Meningococcal.** Get this vaccine if you have HIV, a weak immune system, are at high risk, or live in close spaces like college housing or military barracks.

These vaccines will help protect you and your overall health. You may need some other vaccines, too. This is based on your age, health, or risk factors like if you have diabetes or lung problems with a high risk for an infection called pneumonia. Talk with your care team about which vaccines are best for you.

Infectious Disease Screening

Who? Men who are sexually active.

How often? During yearly exams.

What should you expect? Depending on your lifestyle and medical history, you may need to be screened for chlamydia, syphilis, or other infections. Testing can be done by using a swab of fluid from the penis, drawing your blood, or giving a sample of urine.

All men need to have a one-time test to check for hepatitis C. HIV testing should be done every year at routine exams.

If you have multiple or anonymous sexual partners, your care team may suggest testing every 3-6 months instead of yearly. Early detection and treatment can prevent serious health issues. Talk to your care team about your risk.

Urine and blood samples are checked for some infections.

Dental and Eye Health

Dental Check-ups. Plan for a dental visit every 6 months. A dentist will check your teeth and gums for cavities, gum disease, and other issues. Regular check-ups help keep your mouth healthy.

Eye Exams. Plan for regular eye visits

- Every 5-10 years, if you have no vision problems
- Every 1-2 years, if you wear glasses or contact lenses

An eye doctor will check your vision and eye health. They may use different tools to look at your eyes and check for issues like glaucoma or cataracts.

Summary

Screenings can help you feel more in control of your health and give you peace of mind. Remember, it is always better to know and act than to wait until things get worse. Your care team is there to support your health and wellness.

IF YOU HAVE A MEDICAL EMERGENCY, CALL 911 OR GO TO THE EMERGENCY ROOM.